

Patti Royale — an in-game commerce store

Product Associate assignment · PlaySuper

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Live prototype: <https://daenerysdrag.github.io/patti-royale-playsuper/>

Code: <https://github.com/DaenerysDrag/patti-royale-playsuper>

Best viewed on a laptop — the PM console docks on the right and the reasoning callouts sit beside the phone. Works on mobile too.

Thesis

An in-game store that behaves like a shop will fail, because the player did not come to shop. There is no purchase intent to capture. The job is to convert accumulated play into a reason to play again.

In e-commerce, the cart is dead intent. In a game, the cart is a retention loop.

So I did not build a storefront. I built a coin sink that lifts retention without touching IAP.

Assumptions

WHAT I ASSUMED	
Game	<i>Patti Royale</i> — casual trick-taking cards. 1M DAU, India, Android-first. 1.8 sessions/day, 4 matches/session. Baseline ARPDau ₹0.80
Player	Zero purchase intent on entry. ~40 seconds of attention between matches. Starts from the assumption that in-game "free rewards" are a scam
Archetypes	Grinder (daily, never pays, 528 coins/day) · Dipper (2–3×/week, churn-risk, 61/day) · Whale (buys IAP, 235/day)
Currency	Win 50 · loss 15 · daily streak 40. Peg: 10 coins = ₹1
Non-goals	Does not touch the existing cosmetic coin sink. Does not touch IAP pricing. Coins never buy in-game power
Who pays	🔑 The brand funds the discount as customer-acquisition cost — not the studio

The consequence of that last row

If the brand funds the discount as CAC, then the constraint on this economy is **brand CAC budget and coupon inventory — not coin supply**.

Coins can be generous. What must be rationed is **conversion**. That is why there is a redemption cap (2/week) and no paywall on earning — and it is why I never modelled coins as a studio cost.

Tools used

TOOL	WHAT FOR
Claude Code (Opus 5)	The build — architecture, every screen, the trick-taking match logic, the event bus, the economy derivation, these docs
Claude Design	A parallel visual pass: I designed the store as a multi-screen canvas, then ported its typography, button geometry and instrumentation panel into the working build
React 19 · TypeScript · Vite · Tailwind 4 · framer-motion · zustand	Stack. No backend; state persists to <code>localStorage</code>

TOOL	WHAT FOR
GitHub Pages + Actions	Deploy. Every push to <code>main</code> typechecks, builds and republishes

How I used them matters more than that I used them.

I wrote a **7-phase gated brief** for Claude Code first and made it stop at checkpoints for review, so the decisions stayed mine. Twice it flagged that my own numbers broke — the original earn rate made a "this month" reward affordable in five days, and a single set of price bands cannot be "reach today" for both a Grinder and a Dipper. Both flags changed the design. The economy here is the second version, not the first.

The Claude Design pass was deliberately **not** adopted wholesale, and what I rejected from it is the more useful thing to know. I took its type scale, its pill button geometry, and its instrumentation-panel treatment, which were all better than my first pass. I left behind its light iris-and-cyan palette — a white SaaS surface bolted to a dark felt card table would read as two products — and I left behind its economy readout panel, because that design's own footnote said its funnel and economy figures were "*illustrative, not instrumented*." This build's console can't carry a section it would have to fake.

The core question: how should this differ from e-commerce?

E-COMMERCE ASSUMES	IN-GAME REALITY	SO I BUILT
The user arrives with intent	The player came to play; commerce interrupts	The store opens at the post-match moment , never as a nav tab
Search is the discovery primitive	40-second window; choice paralysis kills it	No search, no filters. 12 items, 3 fixed groups
Price is an economic fact	Coins are printed by the studio and cost the player <i>time</i>	Price shown in effort — "3 more wins" — computed from your earn rate
Not buying is neutral	"You can't afford this" demotivates — damaging the retention this was sold to fix	Zero dead ends. Every locked item shows a ring and a Play button
Currency is fungible cash	A currency that buys real goods will cannibalise IAP	Real-world rewards only. Never in-game power
The store is the destination	Every second in-store costs the studio the session	Exit CTA is "Back to match" , never "Continue shopping"
Returns handle regret	You cannot refund someone's <i>time</i>	Coins refunded if a voucher expires unused. No e-commerce analogue exists
Growth = more traffic	Growth = more reasons to play	Goals — below

Goals — the mechanic the whole thing rests on

Reserve a reward and it becomes a **ring in the game HUD**, price-locked for 7 days. Every hand fills it. At 100% the game tells you.

This inverts the funnel from `browse → buy` into `want → play → afford → buy`. Commerce stops being an interruption and becomes the reason for the next session. It is also the only part of this design that plausibly moves D7 retention — which is what a studio is actually buying.

Two deliberate consequences:

- `goal_created` is the conversion event that matters, not `payment_success`. Creating a goal costs the player nothing and costs the brand nothing, and it is what brings them back.
- **A player holding no goal gets one manufactured.** The reward screen surfaces the nearest out-of-reach item rather than a catalog: close enough to want, far enough to play for.

The economy, and one derivation worth your time

Coin cap is a property of the **item**, never of the player: Tier 1 and 2 are fully coin-funded, **Tier 3 caps coins at 40% and the rest is cash** — PlaySuper's model, and the only place the coin↔cash slider appears. One flat rule, identical for everyone. I deliberately rejected loyalty tiers and engagement-based pricing: charging a more-engaged player more for the same item is manipulative, and it reads that way the moment two players compare screenshots.

Back-solving your published +5.2% ARPDau rather than guessing a redemption rate:

₹0.80 baseline × 5.2% lift	= ₹0.0416 incremental per DAU per day
₹700 order × 10% commission × 50%	= ₹35 studio revenue per redemption
⇒ 0.0416 / 35 = 0.119% of DAU must redeem daily	
⇒ ≈1,189 redemptions/day at 1M DAU ⇒ ≈₹5.35M/month of brand-funded discount	

Only about 1 player in 840 per day. That is a tiny conversion requirement, and it changes the product: optimise for **retention breadth** — many players holding a goal — over **conversion depth**. A held goal costs the brand nothing and returns a player tomorrow; a checkout costs CAC and may not.

It is also why the conversion event I optimise for is **reserving a goal**, not completing a payment. Full funnel and event spec in `docs/03-event-taxonomy.md`.

(₹700 AOV, 10% commission, 50% studio share are my assumptions. If commission is 5%, the required redemption rate doubles and the catalog has to get cheaper — that's the first number I'd want from you.)

One thing I decided not to fake. A delivered coupon is not brand revenue — the brand's real conversion happens off-platform, days later, at the merchant's checkout. So the prototype's console shows the redemption it can observe and greys out the one it cannot, rather than inventing a figure. Closing that gap needs unique per-player codes and a brand-side redemption webhook. Until it exists, every ROI number quoted to a brand is a proxy and should be labelled as one.

North Star: % of DAU holding an active goal.

Guardrails: IAP ARPDau flat-or-up, session length flat-or-up, redemption cap honoured, no coin purchases of in-game power.

Three questions I'd want answered first

Each of these is an assumption I couldn't verify, and each one changes the design rather than just the copy.

1. **What coin-cap ceiling do brands actually accept?** I used 40% on Tier 3. It sets the whole economy and it is a guess.
2. **Who eats fulfilment failure — brand, PlaySuper, or the studio?** A dead coupon damages trust in *the game*, so the studio has the most to lose and the least control. That asymmetry needs an owner before it needs a process.
3. **What is the real commission and studio split?** My headline derivation — 0.12% of DAU — rests on ₹700 × 10% × 50%. At a 5% commission the required redemption rate doubles and this catalog is priced wrong.